

“The Chinese Learner”: Misconceptions and Realities

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Despite intensified internationalization of education through “global cultural flows” (Appadurai 1996) of students and teachers between schools and universities in Anglophone countries and China, Western views of “the Chinese learner” remain largely based on outmoded and stereotypical assumptions long past their use-by date. Countries like Hong Kong and Australia are sites of intense flows of Western and Chinese people and ideas, yet often the opportunities that these interactions present are wasted when those on both sides continue to base their understandings of the “other” on idealized or outdated notions. Such narrow thinking and lack of attention to the very real challenges and dilemmas that can confront those working on both sides of these systems of cultural practice can cause misunderstandings and inhibit opportunities for the development of innovative, creative, and generative ways of teaching and learning.

Teachers and students at sites of rich cross-cultural interactions such as at international schools and universities in Hong Kong or in schools and universities across Australia (or indeed in other parts of the world where there are large numbers of international students such as the UK, US, and Canada) make connections across systems of cultural practice on a daily basis. Their experiences can contribute much to the development of new educational ways of knowing and doing. Yet, rather than basing their actions on what they are seeing and encountering, those working within these systems often base their actions on entrenched stereotypical views of the characteristics of “Western” and “Chinese” learners. As China becomes a more significant player globally, it is imperative that those working with Chinese students, either in Chinese or Western contexts, have an informed understanding of the contemporary realities and complexities of both Anglophone and Asian educational contexts.

Western beliefs about the “inherent” characteristics of “Chinese” learners need to be examined so that a genuine dialogue can be established between (and within) these systems, based on an understanding of, and a mutual respect for, the values and individuals within these systems. This requires an examination of whether the usual characterizations of “Chinese” and “Western” academic values are useful, accurate, or valid and the impacts that ill-informed characterizations can have on individuals. This chapter focuses on recent Western debates about “the Chinese learner,” and provides an analysis of both prevailing “deficit” and more recent “surplus” views of Chinese learners, to examine underlying preconceptions about Chinese learners and learner behaviors, and how the views of Western teachers and academics construct the ways in which these teachers operate within these systems.

Australian views of Chinese learners

Rapid changes to the nature of the student cohort over the past ten to fifteen years at universities in Australia have produced radical changes to educational expectations and outcomes for both teachers and students. This is due to a more multicultural Australian society generally, as well as government policies aimed at the expansion of postsecondary educational opportunities beyond an elite group. At the same time, there have been rapid increases in the numbers of international students studying in Australia. Twenty-four percent of university students and 10 percent of secondary school students are now international students, coming mainly from China, and other “Confucian heritage culture” (hereafter CHC) countries. Among university academics, these changes have produced a range of responses, from those who see this increasing diversity as a source for enriching learning environments for all students, to more negative and sometimes even hostile reactions, often in response to increasing workloads (Ryan 2002). Papastephanou characterizes these as “antagonistic responses cultivated by globalization” (2005, 533). At some Australian universities and secondary schools, especially in major capital cities, there are very large numbers of Chinese students, many whose parents have migrated from China in recent years. For school and university teachers, these changes often produce pressure to internationalize the curriculum and cater for students with different cultural and linguistic backgrounds. Similar reactions have been reported in other Anglophone education systems such as, for example, in the United Kingdom (Ryan 2000; Turner and Robson 2008; Tysome 2004) and New Zealand (Li, Baker and Marshall 2002) or even in Hong Kong, as Forse notes (Chapter 3 in this volume), though it is not an altogether Anglophone system.

It is well recognized within Australia that such educational globalization benefits Australia and enhances productivity and security, especially if these "flows" are used as a platform for better understanding of different cultural traditions, knowledge, and perspectives. However, stereotypical, and often "deficit" views of Chinese learners put at risk the benefits of these "flows" due to the ways that inappropriate stereotypes of "Asian" and "Chinese" students are often promoted in attempts to assist Western teachers to understand "unfamiliar" types of students.

Western research in Anglophone countries often homogenizes Chinese or CHC students and ignores the contemporary complexities and diversity to be found within CHC cultures in the East Asian region such as China, Singapore, and Taiwan (Louie 2005; Ryan and Louie 2005, 2007). Much of the literature on Chinese students in countries such as Australia and the United Kingdom has to date been written by Western instructors working with international students struggling to succeed in unfamiliar cultural and linguistic environments. These tend to identify "deficits" that their international students lack in contrast to academic values supposedly possessed by Western students (Ryan 2002; Ryan 2005a; Ryan and Hellmundt 2003) and are thus often couched as the antithesis of Western exemplars of academic virtue.

"The Chinese learner" debate

Due to these rapid increases in the numbers of Chinese students studying in Anglophone countries such as Australia, the United States, Canada, and the United Kingdom, the "Chinese learner" has become a key recent focus for Western studies in education (Clarke and Gieve 2006; Coverdale-Jones and Rastall 2009; Jin and Cortazzi 2006; Shi 2006; Turner 2006; Watkins and Biggs 1996, 2001).

But definitions of who is meant by "the Chinese learner" vary enormously and are often fuzzy. The terms "Asian" and "Chinese" are often conflated, and Western academics frequently use "Asian" when they are in fact talking about students from China or Confucian heritage cultures.

So just whom do we mean when we refer to "the Chinese learner"? The literature in this area variously refers to "Chinese," "Asian," or more commonly to "Confucian heritage culture" students. Definitions of CHC learners vary enormously but generally include people from the nations of East Asia such as China (including Hong Kong), Taiwan, Singapore, Japan, and Korea (Louie 2005). But the scope and breadth of who is included often varies widely, ranging from researchers such as Kirkpatrick (2004), confining his study to speakers of Modern Standard Chinese from the People's Republic of China, to authors such as Nisbett

(2003), who maps the “geography of thought” of “Asians” and “Westerners,” and includes anyone of Chinese ancestry in the former category:

When I speak of East Asia I mean China and the countries that were heavily influenced by its culture, most notably Japan and Korea. (I will sometimes abbreviate ‘East Asian’ to ‘Easterner’ and sometimes to ‘Asian’.) When I speak of Westerners I mean people of European culture. When I speak of European Americans I mean blacks and whites and Hispanics — anyone but people of Asian descent. (Nisbett 2003, xxii)

Nisbett thus implies, by including “anyone of Asian descent” in his definition, that anyone of ethnic Chinese background who has lived all of their lives in America has similar learning traits and ways of thinking as people living in remote, rural locations in China. This would be equal to claiming that a white student from New York will have similar learning and thinking behaviors as a white student from a rural area in Russia. Such generic characterizations of “Western learners” would be treated with some skepticism, yet Chinese or CHC students continue to be constructed as essentially “non-Western” and described by Western academics in the ways in which they are “different” from Western students. “Chineseness is in effect defined in terms of deviance from Western norms, and generally as being interestingly different within mainstream, that is Western, psychology” (Watkins and Biggs 2001, 4). And as Edward Said (1978) argued, the “East” and the accompanying notion of “Orientalism” are constructs of the West, defined in terms of how they are *not* Western.

Equally, stereotypes of Western learners also exist among Chinese educators. In comparing American and Chinese students’ characteristics, the influential Chinese educator Gu Mingyuan, in trying to highlight aspects of each other’s cultures that could usefully be adopted as well as their drawbacks, stated that American teachers “seldom place very high demands on students . . . American students do not have a sound foundation in reading, writing and arithmetic” (Gu 2001, 197).

The broader such cultural boundaries are drawn, the larger the geographical area becomes, and the less useful and more stereotyping these categories can become. Even within as narrow a definition of “Chinese” as Kirkpatrick’s, much diversity can be found within China itself. Research by Hu (2003) and Shi (2006) has shown that there are significant differences in the learning behaviors and beliefs between students from the more developed, coastal regions of China and those in inland, less developed regions. Singh (2005) similarly found “highly variable” accounts of the learning experiences of final-year undergraduate students from China studying at universities in Australia. Shi (2006) argues that when we consider “Chinese students,” we need to be mindful of “their national, regional,

economic, class and cultural backgrounds, as well as age, religion and gender" (139). As Louie (2005) points out, a student whose parents are professors from Shanghai will have very different "cultural baggage" from one whose parents are peasants from a village in Hunan (23). According to Hu (2005), the notion of *the* "Chinese context" ignores the diverse learning contexts to be found within China and other CHC countries and, Hu argues, is nothing but a myth.

Stereotypes of the "Chinese learner"

The "Chinese learner" literature is a response to Western literature about international students (such as Ballard and Clanchy 1991, 1997), which essentially characterized CHC students as passive learners lacking critical thinking skills (Kumaravadivelu 2003; Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalos 1999). Chinese students' learning characteristics have tended to be identified by Western academics in terms of what they are "lacking" in comparison to their Western counterparts. As Clark and Gieve (2006) argue:

[T]here is a notable tendency in the applied linguistics literature to report the perceptions and reactions of Western instructors which, rather than being interrogated for ethnocentric bias and stereotyping, are validated by recourse to a Confucian heritage explanation which appears plausible rather than being empirically established . . . Much of the evidence produced for the way Chinese students behave in classroom settings has been drawn from reports and perceptions by Western instructors, thus filtered through their own values, expectations and standards. (60–63)

These perceptions have often been based on partial knowledge or misunderstandings of Chinese students but have given rise to negative stereotypes (Littlewood 2009; Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalso 1999) that often define CHC students' learning behaviors and beliefs as the opposites of Western academic values. These deficit views describe Asian students as rote, passive, and superficial learners lacking critical thinking skills (Kumaravadivelu 2003; Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalos 1999; Ryan 2002; Ryan and Louie 2005) and prone to plagiarism (Kirkpatrick 2004; Phan 2006; Ryan 2000).

Ballard and Clanchy's work (1991, 1997) has since been heavily criticized for posing deficit views of international students, and Asian or CHC learners in particular, but what is more interesting to note is how their messages have been accepted uncritically and continue to be used by Western academics, particularly those in Australia where Ballard and Clanchy's work has been enormously influential. Browsing any one of the usual multiple copies of their books in an Australian university library will reveal evidence of frequent use such as

being heavily “dog-eared” and annotated. An examination of the annotations is revealing in seeing how academics have interpreted their work. The sections where the “deficit” or “lacks” that CHC learners are described as having, are heavily underlined and annotated.

Ballard and Clanchy did explicitly warn against the dangers of stereotyping, advising readers to base their judgments on actual events and outcomes, but these warnings appear to have been little heeded. Many academics and educational developers appear to have been selective in the messages that they have taken away, often invoking the so-called deficits of CHC students in seminars and conference papers, focusing on the skills or qualities that international students lack, without any examination of their own cultural biases. Rather than recognizing the possible diverse practices and perspectives found in (all) students’ previous educational experiences, or examining their own failings, they turn these into “deficits” that their students are lacking and need to develop in order to pass the test of Western academic virtues. Not only does it reveal the lack of critical self-awareness on the part of those who ascribe to these macro categories, but it also does not assist them to better understand and appreciate the contemporary characteristics and abilities of those they teach. As Ayako Yoshino, a PhD student from Japan writing in *The Times* in 2004, stated:

It is particularly infuriating to hear problems with such rhetorical styles attributed to imagined inadequacies in the student’s education in their home country. I have often had conversations in which it has been suggested to me that Oriental students come from backgrounds in which originality and critical thinking are valued less than acceptance of orthodoxy. Apart from the lack of critical thinking apparent in the use of the category Oriental, such analysis is misleading because it confuses differences in style of expression with a lack of academic rigour. What it fails to understand is that a prizewinning English academic essay translated word for word into Japanese is likely to be received as clumsy and ill thought out. (Yoshino 2004, 10)

“Western” versus “Confucian” academic values

Further, analyses of “Western” and “Chinese” or “Confucian” student learning behaviors are often couched as binaries such as deep/surface, adversarial/harmonious, independent/dependent, in what Aly (2007) refers to as “taxonomies of difference.” These dichotomies rely on the notion of “ideal” Western students as models to compare with Chinese students (Ryan and Louie 2007; Shi 2006) and assume that individuals within these systems do indeed have these attributes.

Based on my own examination of the literature in this area, these can be classified as follows:

Western	Confucian
• “Deep” learners • Independent learners • Critical thinking • Student-centered learning • Adversarial stance • Argumentative learners • Achievement of the individual • Constructing new knowledge	• “Surface” or rote learners • Dependence on the teacher • “Follow the master” • Respect for the teacher • Harmony • Passive learners • Achievement of the group • Respect for historical texts

This juxtaposition of academic “values” was illustrated in the Call for Papers of the Philosophy of Education Society of Australasia 34th annual conference, *Critical Thinking and Learning: Values, Concepts and Issues*, in Hong Kong in November 2005:

Education in the different countries of Australasia and Asia is informed by widely differing historical and cultural perspectives, from western to Confucian, from liberal to communitarian, from colonial to postcolonial. Hong Kong, in many ways, lies at the crossroads of many of these perspectives. To what extent, for example, are the dominant concepts of thinking and learning a product of “western” cultural values? Might they be in conflict with concepts and values prevalent in many Confucian-heritage cultures that stress the meditative mind, harmony of thought and harmony in relationships, filial piety and a tempered questioning of authority, and the transmission of received wisdom through time? Might the liberal ideal of the independent and autonomous individual clash with communitarian values of identity in relationship?

Intended to prompt discussion of these polarities, this excerpt (deliberately) draws on the binary logic often found in the literature which portrays Chinese and Western education as exclusive and definable. It illustrates the ways that both “Western” and “Asian” values are often described as discrete, homogeneous, and unchanging (Ryan and Louie 2007). These polarities continue to permeate the literature about CHC students and reinforce hegemonic and marginalizing pedagogy and practice. This encourages the labeling and positioning of whole groups of students without looking at contextual teaching and learning factors (Kumaravadivelu 2003; Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalso 1999) such as the impact

on students' learning behaviors of different methods or types of assessment or learning tasks (Ryan 2002) or whether learning contexts facilitate or hinder more interactive learning (Littlewood 2009). As Kumaravadivelu (2003) argues, contemporary research on CHC or "Asian" students is often "ambiguous and contradictory" (710) and, as Louie (2005) reminds us, we need to be cautious about how individuals report their learning beliefs and practices as "what people tell us about their own cultures is often contradicted by other informants from the same culture" (18). Rao and Chan (2009) point to the primary importance of the social context of learning: "it is aspects of the social context, rather than cultural heritage per se that affects student learning . . . We need to consider teaching and learning, not just the Chineseness of students or teachers" (Rao and Chan 2009, 17–18).

Views of "Western" learners are often equally stereotyped. Critical thinking, deep learning, lifelong and "lifewide" learning are promoted as the outcomes of Western education, but these concepts are often under-theorized or lack agreed meanings, particularly pivotal concepts such as "critical thinking." The notion of "critical thinking" is highly contested even within "Western" educational contexts. Hang's (2005) study of the perceptions of this term by academics in a business faculty at a large Australian university found a remarkable lack of common understanding of the term; many academics in the study claimed that, although they could not easily define the concept, they "knew it when they saw it." There are diverse points of view among educational philosophers on how best to define this concept. Mark Mason (2000, 2008), an educational philosopher at the University of Hong Kong, has attempted to defend an integrated conception of critical thinking by considering the ideas of significant theorists such as Robert Ennis, Richard Paul, John McPeck, and Harvey Siegel. Despite such efforts, there is currently no agreement among academics about such an apparently crucial concept, yet international students, especially Chinese students, are often judged as lacking this attribute.

Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalso (1999) have shown that the nature of students' previous educational experiences, rather than the geographical origin of those experiences, can have greater influence on students' teaching and learning behaviors, so that students who attend a school in India, for example, which uses English as the mode for instruction and is modeled on the British tradition, may have learning behaviors that more closely resemble those of students from a prestigious English "public" school rather than those of students from another school in close geographical proximity. Similarly, students attending schools in the more developed coastal areas of China may have vastly different educational experiences and behaviors from those who are attending schools in less developed, inland areas (due in large part to social and economic inequalities;

see, for example, Postiglione 2006, Wong 2009, and World Bank 2008) or those who are attending schools in Hong Kong.

“Whole culture” explanations

Clark and Gieve (2003) believe that these “large culture explanations” make it easier for teachers to “explain away” their difficulties, but they do not help teachers and students to establish a two-way flow of knowledge and understanding. Stereotyped descriptions of teaching and learning practices by Chinese students and teachers are becoming even more irrelevant due to rapid and profound shifts in cultural, social and economic conditions in China (Chan and Rao 2009; Hu 2003; Jin and Cortazzi 2006; Shi 2006; Watkins and Biggs 2001; Yang 2009). Recent research by Chinese scholars is attempting to correct negative stereotypes about Chinese learners. Shi’s (2006) study of 400 middle school ESL students in Shanghai, for example, found that “they show little difference from their Western counterparts by being active learners and preferring a more interactive relationship with their teachers” (Shi 2006, 122). These myths linger, however (Chan and Rao 2009; Littlewood 2009), and legitimize dubious normative teaching and learning practices in Western universities. They have become so prevalent and entrenched that CHC students often internalize these descriptions of themselves, even apologizing for being too “passive” in class (Ryan and Louie 2007). Aronson (2002) describes this as “stereotype threat”; when people are aware of stereotypes about them, and this results in an extra emotional or cognitive burden and “disidentification” — a lack of interest, motivation, and engagement, the stereotype then becomes a “self-fulfilling prophesy.”

Stereotyped views of CHC learners have also been influenced by the seminal work of Hofstede (1980) who defined the different “dimensions” of culture — “power distance,” “individualism-collectivism,” “masculinity-femininity,” and “uncertainty avoidance” — which provides a framework to chart the general characteristics of societies. As Louie (2005) argues, CHC cultures have been commonly characterized using this framework as being collectivist, having a low “uncertainty avoidance” and a high “power distance” (i.e., hierarchical). A group of Chinese researchers called “The Chinese Culture Connection” (1987) challenged the universality of Hofstede’s classification system and constructed a fifth dimension — “Confucian work dynamism” — encompassing elements found in the teachings of Confucius, such as persistence and perseverance, observing status distinctions, and valuing thrift. In a similar vein to Nisbett’s “whole culture” categorizations, Hofstede (1997) adopts this dimension to cater for what he calls the “Eastern mind” as opposed to the “Western mind” (Louie 2005, 20).

This categorization work acts to classify whole groups of students on the basis of culture. P. Smith (1996) describes this drawing of boundaries around certain types of people or individuals on the basis of those who belong or do not belong to particular categories as “cultural cartography” (in Smith’s study, this refers to people with a disability). This not only confines students within these boundaries but also can act to “pathologize” and marginalize those outside these boundaries. P. Smith (1996) argues that they then become “reified, commodified, and objectified, providing a rationale for continued de-humanization and oppression” (117). They act to generate myths about groups of students and create false “reputations,” often with severe consequences for students labeled as “different” (Winslade and Monk 1998). These myths linger and legitimize dubious teaching and learning practices based on cultural stereotypes long past their usefulness. They ignore the constantly changing, dynamic nature of cultures. As Clark and Gieve (2006) observe: “this entails a sense of cultural fixity, and a notion of historicisation only in the sense that cultures are determined by a historical heritage rather than emerging through history and thus dynamically evolving” (55). Gu Mingyuan (2001) argues that this dynamism is an essential element in the formation of new cultural ways of being and knowing: “cultural traditions are dynamic and ever developing . . . Only after a period of conflict, clashes and confrontation between cultural traditions and modernisation can culture be transformed” (105–106).

Many researchers acknowledge the dangers of stereotyping but nevertheless often proceed to do precisely that. Nisbett (2003) states, for example:

I wish to apologize in advance to those people who will be upset to see billions of people labeled with the single term “East Asian” and treated as if they are identical. I do not mean to suggest that they are even close to being identical. The cultures and subcultures of the East differ as dramatically from one another as do those of the West. But the broad-brush term “East Asian” can be justified. (Nisbett 2003, xxii)

Counters to stereotyping the Chinese learner

The myths about CHC learners as passive, rote learners have been effectively debunked through the work of John Biggs and David Watkins, educationalists at the University of Hong Kong (Watkins and Biggs 1996, 2001) and many others (Chalmers and Volet 1997; Chan and Drover 1997; Coverdale-Jones 2006; Geake and Maingard 1999; Hellmundt 2001; Jones 1999; Kember and Gow 1991; Littlewood 2009; Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalos 1999; O’Donoghue 1996; Volet and Ang 1998). But these views continue to be pervasive in the literature about

CHC and Chinese students. Wen and Clément (2003), for example, characterize Chinese students as passive due to their willingness to submit to authority and claim that this explains their apparent unwillingness to participate in class (in this case, English-language classes).

Newer, what may be termed "surplus," theories of CHC learners (Ryan and Louie 2005), or "cultural proficiency" theories (Ninnes, Aitchison, and Kalos 1999), are attempting to counter these "deficit" theories. Surplus theories seek to identify more positive aspects of Chinese "cultures of learning" (Watkins and Biggs 2001) and to explain the "paradox of the Chinese learner" (Biggs 1996, 45) who achieves "good" results despite "bad" teaching and learning habits (Louie 2005). Surplus theories often portray CHC students as being cooperative, deep learners who are diligent, hard-working, and "[i]nvariably . . . have a high regard for education" (Lee 1996, 25). Although many CHC students do have a high regard for education, many do not, and typifying them in these ways can have negative impacts on those who are motivated by other concerns and interests. As Murphy (2005) has shown, the surplus view of Chinese people as a "model minority" can in fact be traced back to the post-Civil War immigration period in America and is also sometimes seen in contemporary debates in the United States on student test attainment based on ethnic background, without necessarily paying due regard to social and economic influences.

Although the "cultural proficiency" literature is welcome in redressing views of Chinese or CHC learners as "inferior" to their Western counterparts, and has thus performed a vital service, caution needs to be exercised to ensure that one set of myths is not merely replaced with another and that so-called Confucian educational values are not invoked to create equally stereotyped views of Chinese learners (Ryan and Louie 2007). Moving from a "deficit" set of theories to equally problematic "surplus" ones may also have negative impacts on individual students and may not be helpful for teachers trying to understand the learning needs of their students. Neither of these polarized views is helpful in establishing genuine dialogue between these systems which is based upon mutual appreciation of the values and knowledge within both systems.

This is not to say that well-founded and informed contemporary knowledge about learners from different types of educational backgrounds (both geographic and demographic) is not helpful in understanding possible differences in students' experiences and expectations; it is, and students' (and teachers') difficulties are very real. However, it is not useful to attribute the source of these difficulties to "large culture" explanations; rather, what is needed are broader and more holistic attempts to understand the possible multiple sources of these difficulties or misconceptions, as arising from individuals' cultures (large or small, local or national) as well as many other individual or group-based features.

“Confucian” values

CHC students’ learning characteristics are often inaccurately attributed by Western educators to the influence of Confucian values. Rather than being interrogated for ethnocentric bias, the perceptions of Western instructors “are validated by recourse to a Confucian heritage explanation which appears plausible rather than being empirically established” (Clark and Gieve 2006, 63). Recent claims about the influence of Confucianism on the behaviors of Chinese students and scholars ignore the “multi-dimensionality” and diverse manifestations of Confucianism (Shi 2006; Yao 2000) and demonstrate the ways that Confucianism has been interpreted over the centuries to suit various political, economic, and social agendas (Bell 2008; Jensen 1997; Louie 2005; Watkins and Biggs 2001; Wu 2008). Assertions about values such as communitarianism, respect for knowledge and the traditional can be questioned in terms of whether these values are even exclusive to Confucianism. Chinese scholars, as shown by Louie (1986), have in recent decades been engaged in heated controversies in negating these values as inherent to Confucianism:

[T]hese values are not just Asian: they can be found in other societies as well. While some good work was done in this area, the so-called “Asian values” or “Confucian heritage” could be devised by putting together conservative ideas and calling them Asian and Confucian. (Ryan and Louie 2005, 5)

Contemporary interpretations of Confucianism are varied and complex, and, many argue, are often far removed from the original ideas: there is a problem in that “Lee Kuan Yew can call Singapore a ‘Confucian’ society, when many of its values are far indeed from what Confucius would even recognise” (Watkins and Biggs 2001, 4). And as Louie (2005) argues, “in the last century, interpretations of Confucianism, particularly that of Confucian education, have undergone transformations that have at times rendered any commonly accepted interpretation meaningless” (7). Louie (2005) argues that Confucian values are extolled and appropriated for political or economic agendas such as when Asia prospers economically and “Asian values” or “Confucian education” are then eulogized as the keys to successful teaching and learning. More recently, the establishment by the Chinese government of “Confucian Institutes” in many countries around the world to teach Chinese language and culture, and the promotion of Confucian values such as “the building of a harmonious society through an individual’s self-refinement in manners and taste” (Embassy of the People’s Republic of China in Australia 2007) have been seen by some as a “propaganda vehicle for the Chinese Communist party” (Lane 2007).

Based on his experience in teaching students in China, and discussions with students, Slethaug (2007) argues that "Confucianism as a philosophical system is increasingly remote from what actually goes on in Asian countries or what students see as reality" (53). Despite the resurgence in interest in Confucianism in China in recent years, at least in part due to concerns about the increasing materialism and *lack* of Confucian "values" among China's youth (Yu 2008), according to Chin (2007), "We give him [Confucius] credit for all that has gone right and wrong in China because we do not really know him" (2).

Similarly, the supposed influence of the "moral" character imbued within Confucian models of teaching (Hu 2002) can also be called into question in the light of contemporary realities in China such as widespread incidences of corruption, a tendency towards advancement through personal connections (*guanxi*) rather than personal merit or ability, and the valuing by many of personal material and economic gains over moral development and virtue. Many influential scholars are now reinterpreting Confucian education as a path to wealth and democracy, but such a view "would have been considered outrageous heresy by any traditional Confucian" (Louie 2005, 21).

Continuing to focus on the influences of Confucianism also ignores the multiple other religious and philosophical ideologies to be found throughout China and the Asian region and the fact that the philosophical tenets of Confucian are often combined with other religious belief systems and practices. In China, for example, there are significant populations of Buddhists, Daoists, Christians, and Muslims, as well as the fifty-five officially recognized minority cultures.

Impacts on students

Negative (or positive) stereotyping of students can have harmful effects on individuals (Hellmundt and Ryan 2003; Kumaravadivelu 2003; Ryan 2002) and "in reducing individuals to inadequately understood group characteristics, approach racial stereotyping" (Clark and Gieve 2006, 69). Louie (2005) argues that, due to the inherent imbalance of teacher-student power relationships, deficit views have potentially powerful effects on students:

The deficit view of international students is not effective pedagogically because it assumes not only that that some cultures are in "deficit", but that cultural baggage is carried only by students, not teachers. In reality, being the more powerful partner in the teacher-student relationship, the cultural baggage carried by the teachers has a more dominant effect than that carried by the students. (Louie 2005, 23)

These descriptions are not only usually inaccurate, they can also be offensive to those whom they purport to describe, and are often actively resisted by them (Kenway and Bullen 2003; Phan 2004; Ryan 2002). Vietnamese teachers of English as a Second Language (ESL) interviewed by Phan Le Ha (2004) also rejected these stereotypes as inaccurate and offensive: “Importantly, their awareness of such views has indicated that the notion of ‘us’ and ‘them’ has been so obvious and powerful in ELT [English language teaching] practice that it is hard to eliminate” (Phan 2004, 56).

My own Chinese students (both undergraduate and postgraduate) are often in fact critical of some aspects of Western academic approaches such as essay writing that use what they consider to be superficial techniques to selectively extract excerpts from texts to assist in the construction of an argument. As one Masters student commented, a requirement of any level of postgraduate study in China requires a critical self-reflection, which is not necessarily found in or required of their Western counterparts at this level.

Lumping international students (and teachers) together as a “fixed, reified, homogenous and homogenised group” (Clark and Gieve 2006, 63) produces “essentialising accounts of identity” (Kenway and Bullen 2003) and obscures and conflates important differences on the basis of religion, class, gender, and socio-economic background. These one-dimensional accounts, according to Kenway and Bullen (2003), result in the “collectivization” of international students (in this case of women international students) and “collude in the reproduction of discourses of ‘othering’ and, thus, in the establishment and perpetuation of power differentials” (9). Deficit views prevail despite the fact that international students have often previously achieved considerable academic success and professional status within their home country (Ryan 2002) and are often more highly qualified than local students (Bullen and Kenway 2003). These messages not only have powerful impacts on individual international students, but they can also put pressure on them to conform to the “norms and protocols of the host society” (Li, Baker and Marshall 2002, 18).

Many international students I have interviewed or worked with over the past ten years have described their loss of identity and self-esteem when they study in a foreign learning environment, especially when this involves another language and when they feel that they have to comply with the norms of the new learning environment (Ryan 2000, 2002, 2005). This has also been reported in other Australian studies (Hellmundt 2001; Kenway and Bullen 2003; Ryan and Viete 2009; Viete and Peeler 2005), and the sense of isolation and loss of identity upon becoming a member of a visible minority in a foreign mainstream has also been well documented elsewhere (Ellsworth 1997; hooks 1994; Rich, 1986; Vogt 2002). These accounts remind us of the consequences

for individuals when their learning needs are not well understood or when they feel isolated or marginalized.

It is worth remembering, however, that stereotyping is a pervasive phenomenon, not restricted to people in the West (Kumaravadivelu 2003). During my own time as an “outsider,” while I was studying as an international student at universities in China, I not only experienced racial stereotyping myself, but often witnessed more damaging overt discrimination and occasionally even violence towards black African students.

Impacts on teachers

Not only students need to adapt to their new learning environments, but teachers also “must address issues such as cultural imperialism and the stereotypical attitudes relating to Asian students and their learning approaches” (Li, Baker, and Marshall 2002, 18). However, negative reactions by staff are somewhat understandable in the context of rapidly deteriorating professional conditions and increased work pressures for many teachers and lecturers, in part due to the changing nature of the student cohort in universities and schools (both in Australia and Hong Kong), and teachers often report their frustration at their lack of training in teaching students from culturally different backgrounds (Ryan 2002; Turner and Robson 2008). Ninnes and Hellstén (2005) call this a “moment of exhaustion” (4) as the radical changes to teachers’ work can mean that academics’ and teachers’ reactions are sometimes negative and even hostile. These reactions are often aimed at those who most obviously display the physical manifestation of these changes. Clark and Gieve (2003) argue that blaming students can make it easier for teachers to “explain away” their difficulties as being caused by something that is beyond their control.

In our attempt to deal with the complexity of our task [as TESOL teachers], we fall for simple, sometimes simplistic, solutions. We may be stereotyping our learners partly because it helps us reduce an unmanageable reality to a manageable label. (Kumaravadivelu 2003, 716)

Teachers working with students from unfamiliar cultural (or social) backgrounds need to learn how to make connections between students’ previous experiences and expectations of learning and help students to make links across different cultural and social practices and expectations. Where the teacher is working with large numbers of students from culturally different backgrounds, and especially where a teacher is working in a host country where the culture is significantly different from their home country, teachers need to be sensitive to different cultural knowledge and perspectives. They also need to try to understand

that the ways students react may be different from what they have come to expect. Teachers need to act as a bridge for their students to assist them in adapting to, and learning about, new ways of thinking and doing, so that both teachers and learners can become effective intercultural operators and communicators. Teachers cannot possibly learn about the cultural backgrounds of all of their students, but they can develop what Louie (2005) calls meta-cultural sensitivity. Such an approach

involves understanding both host and home culture, how these cultures can be both beneficial and harmful. To do so involves “stepping back” from both cultures and to understand them as systems. That is, to take a meta approach to all cultures . . . With that skill, all cultures can be appraised and utilised, without having to think that bits and pieces should be valued or condemned. Many students come from rapidly changing cultures and those who succeed in life learn to manage the cultural changes within their own cultures skillfully. (Louie 2005, 23)

This bridging of cultural divides is a daily negotiation process that occurs in the “humble spaces” (both physical and mental) of the classroom (Slethaug 2007, 64) in the direct contact between teachers and students in more globalized contexts. This is the “gift” that teaching in cross-cultural contexts can bring for both students and teachers alike. People from outside a culture can often see things more clearly than those embedded within that culture and can assist us to better understand, and then change, our views and practices. I did not fully understand my own “Australianess” until I spent two years studying in China (interestingly, and surprisingly, this also occurred while I was an international student in the United Kingdom). This experience not only changed my views of the world, but also of myself and what I had until then considered to be the natural and universal way of things. Intercultural experiences help you to become an “anthropologist” of your own culture and to see it anew; forcing you to learn about the “self” through the “other.” We learn more about ourselves as well as others, as we bring our “mixture of affiliated identities” (Slethaug 2007, 187) to these learning contexts.

This mixture of affiliated identities can work to the advantage of those who have been raised with multi-ethnic, multi-cultural, and cross-cultural perspectives and can easily be seen as a metaphor for the generative constructing and blending of different affiliated identities in the cross-cultural classroom. (Slethaug 2007, 187)

It is important also to remember that stereotypes of Chinese scholarship and learning can also have negative impacts on teachers. In my current collaborative work between Chinese, Canadian, and Australian academics and school teachers on curriculum reform and teacher professional development in China, the

Chinese academics and teachers expressed their dismay at being characterized in these deficit ways (Mitchell, Ryan, Kang, and Erikson 2007). They rejected characterizations of Chinese teaching as teacher-directed, textbook-dominated, and lacking in creativity and innovation. Instead, their teaching practices are aimed at experimenting with high levels of student-teacher interaction and innovation, and they are constantly engaged in researching, publishing, disseminating, reflecting, and seeking feedback on their teaching beliefs and practice (see Beijing Normal University and Beijing Zhongguansun Number 4 School 2006 and 2007).

Changing contexts

These stereotypes also ignore the dynamic and changing nature of cultures as starkly demonstrated by the rapid and profound physical, social, and cultural transformations that are currently occurring in China. Chinese "cultures of learning" (Watkins and Biggs 2001) are changing so radically that stereotyped descriptions of teaching and learning practices by Chinese students and teachers are increasingly out of date (Hu 2003, 2005; Jin and Cortazzi 2006; Ryan and Louie 2005; Shi 2006). Chan and Rao (2009) thus speak of the need to "transcend" dichotomies and binary thinking. China changes physically each year beyond recognition, so much so that even the superficial physical transformations have many of their own citizens feeling "dazed and lost in the new landscape" (Louie 2005, 21). In addition, Chinese researchers are beginning to speak for themselves about contemporary education contexts and learner diversity in China (Fan, Wong, Cai, and Li 2004; Hu 2003, 2005; Shi 2006; Zhu and Kang 2002).

China's national education curriculum reform over the past five to ten years (Fan, Wong, Cai, and Li 2004; Guan and Meng 2007; Kang 2007; Ma and Tang 2002; Ma, Yin, Tang, and Liu 2009; Mitchell, Ryan, Kang, and Erikson 2007; Zhu 2005; Zhu and Kang 2002) has signaled China's intention to radically change pedagogy and curriculum at all levels of education. These reforms were launched with the release of the Guidelines on Chinese Basic Education Curriculum Reform (*Zhongguo jichu jiaoyu kecheng gaige gangyao*) published by the Ministry of Education (MOE) in 2001. This has entailed a move from the "two basics" — "shuang ji" (knowledge and skill) — to educational reform and the growth of new and innovative teaching and learning approaches..

These changes can be characterized as a concern to move from teacher-directed to student-centered education, and to "quality-oriented education" (Kang 2007; Liu 2006; Mitchell, Ryan, Kang, and Erikson 2007; Zhu 2005; Zhu and Kang 2002). Contemporary examples of such approaches were showcased at an international conference on curriculum reform attended by six hundred teachers and university academics from eight provinces across China

in 2007 (the *Learning and Developing Community First Annual Conference*, held in Dongsheng, Inner Mongolia in July 2007). These approaches embody a concern to move towards “more attention to the real and individual needs of students, teacher-student interaction in a range of engaging and diverse learning activities, more open and positive, interactive learning environments, and more equitable teacher-student relationships” (Kang 2007; Mitchell, Ryan, Kang, and Erikson 2007; Ryan 2007). At many schools in China, especially in large cities such as Beijing, Shanghai, and Guangzhou, but also in more remote areas such as Inner Mongolia (Mitchell, Ryan, Kang, and Erikson 2007), and in Gansu Province (Hannum and Park 2007; Robinson 2008; Sargent and Hannum 2008) this work is well advanced.

In China, there is a robust debate about the challenges and dilemmas surrounding the integration of Chinese and Western notions of learning and scholarship (especially in the area of communicative language teaching). In the “Preface” to a recent publication by the Hong Kong-based pro-Confucianist Yew Chung Education Foundation, *The Analects: A Modern Translation and Contemporary Interpretation*, Professor Yip Kwok-wah (2006), although advocating learning from the Confucian *Analects* to “provide a new impetus for China’s rejuvenation” (ix), nevertheless also acknowledges that there is a need to “brutally attack and negate the dross of Confucianism” (xv). These types of debates are assisting Chinese educationalists from a range of perspectives to try to rejuvenate China’s educational system by critically examining its current and traditional academics beliefs and practices while attempting to learn from the best of Western ideas. Western countries need to do the same. Like China, Western educators need to recognize that the essence of scholarship and learning involves the “brutal” interrogation of conventional intellectual wisdoms and the critical falsifying of the known. Much can be learned from other conventional and emerging traditions of scholarship and learning, but this needs to be based on an informed debate about contemporary Western and Confucian education realities and complexities.

Implications for teachers in cross-cultural contexts

Teachers working in cross-cultural contexts need to understand the role of culture in influencing and mediating teaching and learning in both historical and contemporary contexts. The most influential contemporary theory of learning in Western educational contexts is constructivist theory, which is the belief that we progressively and actively build our knowledge based on what we already know. It gives prominence to the role of prior experiences and expectations in determining what is taught and what is learned. Through our first-hand or vicarious experiences,

we develop ever more complex and sophisticated understandings of everyday and abstract concepts. Our understanding of the concept "football," for example, will vary according to our previous physical, social, and cultural experiences of this phenomenon. So these may differ vastly according to whether we have lived in Europe, the United States, China, or Australia (where this concept will refer to completely different codes of sport) or whether we have previously mainly played or watched this sport. This simple example illustrates how our social and cultural experiences (and accordingly, our expectations) exert strong influences on how and what we learn and how and what we teach. Teachers need to bear this in mind in cross-cultural classrooms and be mindful of the cultural basis of their knowledge and actions, and the possible gaps in knowledge or differences in expectations that may exist for their students.

Education, by its very nature, draws upon historical, cultural knowledge and understandings. Teachers need to be aware (1) of the basis of the assumptions that they make about knowledge, academic "values," and teacher-student interactions, (2) of the "cultural baggage" we all carry in these areas, and (3) of our need to both gather and impart cultural knowledge and understandings. Although working in cross-cultural contexts involves both challenges and rewards, it offers a transformative opportunity for inter- and intra-cultural learning. That is, it helps us to see anew the nature of our own historical and cultural assumptions and understandings, as well as those of others. This means that we need to recognize and appreciate the diversity and complexity within and between not only other cultures, but also our own. "Interflows" of students and teachers need not be seen as a "problem" but an opportunity for mutual learning. This can only be achieved, however, through genuine dialogue between educational systems based upon a mutual respect for and recognition of contemporary Chinese and Anglophone realities, knowledge, and perspectives.

In order for educators to work more collaboratively and effectively in globalized environments and take advantage of opportunities to broaden and regenerate intellectual understandings and traditions, it is important to reject simplistic and homogenizing rhetoric. Instead of confining ourselves to how cultures are different from one another, if educators look more to identifying similarities and commonalities and what can be learnt from one another, intercultural experiences and cultural flows of ideas and knowledge can help us to understand the things that unite rather than divide us. This is what Ivy Wang and Weibin Zhu (Chapters 8 and 9 of this volume) describe as the significant value of their cross-cultural and transnational teaching in Guangzhou. The real benefits of increased cultural flows between Anglophone and Chinese educational contexts will not be achieved while existing and entrenched binary and outmoded views of "Western" and "Chinese" notions of scholarship and learning continue to prevail.

Although negative Western views of Chinese students are still dominant, the more recent “surplus” theories are equally problematic and may perpetuate stereotyped and misconceived views about Chinese students and the unrealistic “glorification” of internationalization of education.

Literature in the fields of comparative and international education, educational development and applied linguistics often focuses on differences *between* cultures. This is not to say that there are not differences between cultures; there are. But there is often more diversity to be found *within* cultures than *between* them. Individuals who do fit the stereotypes of either Chinese or Western students can be found, and there is some merit in using properly constructed Weberian “ideal types” when they are used critically in determining whether certain defined clusters of values and attributes do or do not have explanatory power. Li (2009) argues that it is important to describe ideals “because they exist in people’s minds and guide people’s behavior” (48) but broadly applying often partial, inaccurate, or outdated stereotypes across whole cultural systems and to all individuals within them can lead to bad teaching practices and lost learning opportunities in the international classroom, leaving students feeling “untaught and distraught” (Sanderman-Gay 1999, 46).

Stereotypes about the function of teachers or about students from different kinds of cultures can sometimes jeopardize the best intentions for a classroom. This concern can exist equally whether internationalizing education at home or abroad. (Slethaug 2007, 61)

Intercultural experiences, whether through working with students in another culture or through contact at home with students from other cultures, help us to broaden our worldviews. They help us to identify issues of concern common across regions and cultures. This stance needs to be based on respectful and informed dialogue and sharing of ideas and knowledge, on what Hayhoe and Pan (2001) call a “true dialogue among ready listeners” as means to counter “clash of civilizations” rhetoric (21). It needs to focus less on comparing and contrasting educational and cultural systems, and more with ways to effectively work together as educators. According to Dr Kang Changyun of Beijing Normal University, good teaching and learning are “the common treasures of humanity.”